

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

A COURT-MANDATED SURVEY OF THE HISTORIC MOSQUE LEADS TO FURTHER ESCALATION WITH CONTESTED CLAIMS OF A HIDDEN LINGAM BEING DISCOVERED. COULD KASHI BE THE NEW AYODHYA?

BY SHREEVATSA NEVATIA

On May 16, chants of '*Baba mil gaye*' came to fill the streets outside Varanasi's Gyanvapi mosque. A court-mandated survey of the masjid had reportedly thrown up evidence strengthening the suspicion of several Hindu believers and religious outfits: Gyanvapi could have been built on the foundation of the famed Vishweshwara Temple that Aurangzeb destroyed in 1669. The floral motifs on the mosque walls were a clue of sorts, but it was, finally, the apparent discovery of a *linga*-like structure that had devotees excited about parts of a temple lying buried below.

As news spread that a purported '*shivalinga*' had been found inside the masjid compound, Varanasi resident Manju Vyas wanted to immediately go inside Gyanvapi for "*darshan*". When told that women weren't allowed inside Gyanvapi, she retorted, "We're going to a temple, not a mosque." Vyas, along with four women petitioners, had moved a local court on August 18 last year, demanding they be allowed to worship Shringar Gauri 365 days a year. Enshrined on a red stone platform that rests on Gyanvapi's western wall, the goddess is worshipped only on one day of the year—the Chaturthi (fourth day) of Chaitra Navratri.

The plaintiffs had a second appeal: they wished to pray to all "visible and invisible deities within the old temple complex". On April 26, when the Varanasi court assured the petitioners that the disputed Gyanvapi site would be inspected, there were some who found in the decision a resonance of the Ayodhya Ram Janmabhoomi case. In that case, too, the court commissioner's survey had proved to be key.

V.N. Arora, former principal of Saket Degree College in Ayodhya, explains, "In the Ayodhya case, it was the civil judge of Faizabad who had appointed the court commissioner on April 1, 1950, to prepare the map of the disputed site. In the entire case thereafter, from the high court to the Supreme Court, the report of the court commissioner was discussed. The same report is also part of the Supreme Court's decision in November 2019." Litigation apart, one can already hear in the arguments of some Banarasis a ratcheting up of emotion that seems reminiscent of 1992.

Advocate Sudheer Tripathi represents Vyas and her fellow petitioners in the Varanasi court. He insists his clients have almost won their case: "You can no longer call Gyanvapi a masjid. Have you ever heard of a masjid that has in it a *shivalinga* or idols of other Hindu gods and goddesses? Wouldn't it be great if by reaching an understanding we could give a message to the world that in India we solve age-old differences through reconciliation? The decision is theirs—to give it to us now or give it later."

Gyanvapi's caretaker committee, the Anjuman Intizamiya Masjid (AIM), says it prefers to keep its faith in the 1991 Places of Worship (Special Provisions) Act than react to veiled threats. Passed by the Narasimha Rao